
TMJ and Jaw Tension

Why your face is doing more work than you realize — and how to teach it to rest

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Introduction

A BETWEEN-SESSIONS MODULE ON THE MUSCLE that's been working overtime without your permission.

Put your fingers on the corners of your jaw right now and clench. Feel that muscle pop? That's your masseter, and for most of you, it's been working overtime without your permission.

I see jaw tension on my table every week. Sometimes the client knows that's why they're there — they've been told they grind, they've got a night guard, their dentist sent them. More often, they came in for neck pain or headaches and we trace it back to the jaw. The jaw was the source the whole time. The neck was just where it ended up screaming.

Here's what most people don't realize: your jaw is connected to your neck, your shoulders, your sleep, and your stress level. It's not an isolated joint. It's a load-bearing piece of your whole upper-body tension story. And most of you are carrying more tension in your face than you've ever consciously noticed.

This is the module to fix that.

CHAPTER 1

TMJ basics — what you're actually dealing with

THE TMJ IS THE TEMPOROMANDIBULAR JOINT — the hinge where your lower jaw connects to your skull, right in front of your ears. You have two of them, one on each side. Put a finger right in front of each ear and open and close your mouth; you'll feel them move.

Around that joint sit three main muscles that do the work of chewing, clenching, and (for most of you) bracing against stress all day long.

The masseter

Big, thick muscle running from your cheekbone down to your jaw. You can feel it bulge when you clench. It's one of the strongest muscles in your body relative to its size — it has to be, to crush food. When it's overworked, it gets sore, it gets fat (literally — chronic clenchers develop visibly larger jaw muscles), and it pulls on your temples and your neck.

The temporalis

Fan-shaped muscle on the side of your head, above your ear. Put your fingers on your temples and clench — feel it move? That's the temporalis. When it's tight, you get headaches at the temples. The kind that wrap around the side of your head and feel like a band squeezing.

The pterygoids

Two pairs of deeper muscles that move your jaw side-to-side and forward. You can't easily feel these from the outside — they're inside your mouth, behind the cheek and under the jaw. When they're tight, they pull your jaw out of alignment and create that “clicky” feeling when you open your mouth.

These three groups, working together, are what gets locked up when you clench, grind, or carry stress in your face.

CHAPTER 2

Most people don't know they clench

HERE'S THE PART THAT SURPRISES CLIENTS. Most people who have jaw tension don't know they're clenching. They might know they grind their teeth at night because a dentist or a partner told them. But the daytime clenching — the steady, low-grade, all-day bracing — happens completely outside of awareness for most people.

The signs to check for:

- Sore jaw in the morning, especially right where the muscle bulges below your cheekbone
- Worn tooth surfaces (the dentist will see this before you will)
- Headaches that start at the temples and wrap around
- A “tired” feeling in your face by afternoon
- Your teeth touching when your mouth is at rest

That last one is the tell. Healthy resting position is **lips together, teeth apart, tongue resting on the roof of your mouth**. If your teeth are touching when

you're not actively chewing or swallowing, your jaw is working. Not relaxed.

Most of you check right now and find your teeth touching. That's clenching. You just didn't have a word for it.

CHAPTER 3

The jaw-neck connection

THIS IS THE PIECE MOST PEOPLE MISS, INCLUDING most dentists. The jaw doesn't operate in isolation. The same nerves that control jaw muscles also feed muscles in your neck and upper back. Tightness flows in both directions.

A tight masseter pulls down on your jaw, which pulls on the muscles under your chin, which pull on the front of your neck. Meanwhile, the tight temporalis pulls up and back, which pulls on the muscles at the base of your skull. The whole upper-neck region tightens.

Coming the other way: if you have a forward head posture from desk work or phone use, the muscles at the base of your skull (suboccipitals) tighten to hold your head up. They share innervation with the jaw muscles. Tight neck back-end → jaw braces in response. It's a feedback loop.

This is why I almost never work only on someone's jaw if they come in for jaw pain. I work on the jaw AND the upper neck AND the shoulders. Treat one

without the others and the problem comes back within a few days.

CHAPTER 4

What actually helps

THREE SELF-RELEASE TECHNIQUES. NONE REQUIRE TOOLS. All three can be done sitting in your car at a stoplight or at your desk between meetings.

1. External masseter release

Press your fingertips into the bulgy part of your masseter — right below your cheekbone, on the meaty part of your jaw. Press firmly enough to feel the muscle, not so hard you hurt yourself. Move your fingertips in small slow circles for 30 seconds on each side.

You'll often feel a "knot" or a tender spot. Stay on it. Breathe. The muscle will start to soften as you hold attention there.

2. Temporalis release

Fingertips on your temples. Same small slow circles, same 30 seconds each side. The temporalis fan is bigger than people realize — work the area from your hairline back to the top of your ear.

If you get headaches, this is the one. Do it three times a day for a week and your headache frequency often drops noticeably.

3. Jaw mobility — open, side-to-side, forward

With your face relaxed:

- Open your mouth slowly as wide as comfortable (no forcing, no clicking sounds). Hold 2 seconds. Close.
- Move your jaw slowly to the right as far as comfortable. Hold 2 seconds. Center.
- Move your jaw slowly to the left. Hold 2 seconds. Center.
- Push your jaw slightly forward (lower teeth in front of upper). Hold 2 seconds. Return.
- Repeat the whole sequence 3 times.

This restores range of motion that gets lost when you're locked in a clench all day.

CHAPTER 5

When to combine massage with dental care

I GET ASKED ALL THE TIME WHETHER SOMEONE should get a night guard or come in for bodywork. The honest answer is usually both, in this order:

Night guard first if you grind at night and you're damaging teeth. The night guard protects the teeth. It doesn't fix the underlying tension — it just keeps you from grinding through your enamel while you fix the rest.

Bodywork in parallel to actually address the muscle tension. The night guard alone often doesn't reduce jaw soreness because the muscles are still clenching all day; they're just clenching against plastic at night instead of teeth.

See a dentist if you have any of these: - Joint clicking or popping that's painful - Your jaw locks open or closed - Sharp shooting pain when you chew - Difficulty opening your mouth past 2-3 fingers wide

Those are signs of joint dysfunction, not just muscle tightness. Get the joint evaluated before you try to “stretch through it.”

CHAPTER 6

Your daily 10-minute jaw reset

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS MODULE, do this every day. Pick a fixed time — morning routine works best.

Minute 1 — Awareness check. Sit quietly. Bring attention to your face. Are your teeth touching? Is your tongue on the roof of your mouth? Just notice.

Minute 2-3 — External masseter release. 30 seconds each side, fingertips, small slow circles.

Minute 4-5 — Temporalis release. 30 seconds each side, fingertips, small slow circles.

Minute 6 — Jaw mobility sequence. Open, side-to-side, forward. 3 rounds.

Minute 7 — Breath reset. Five slow nasal breaths. Inhale 4 counts, exhale 6 counts. Belly moves, shoulders don't.

Minute 8 — Resting position practice. Lips together. Teeth apart. Tongue on the roof of your mouth. Hold this position for 1 minute. This is what you're training your face to default to.

Minute 9-10 — Three jaw check-ins for the day.

Pick three reminders for later — coming back from lunch, mid-afternoon, before bed. At each one, just check: are my teeth touching? If yes, drop the jaw. Tongue to roof of mouth. Three breaths.

That's the whole prescription. Ten minutes once. Three check-ins through the day.

CHAPTER 7

Closing

CHECK YOUR JAW THREE TIMES A DAY. JUST NOTICE. Are your teeth touching? They shouldn't be. Lips together, teeth apart, tongue on the roof of your mouth. That's your new resting position.

The jaw is the most under-acknowledged muscle group in chronic upper-body pain. It's also one of the easiest to address once you know what you're looking for — because the muscles are right there, on the outside of your face, accessible to your own fingers anytime you want them.

Most clients who actually work this for two weeks come back to my table with looser jaws, fewer headaches, and a strange new awareness of how much they were carrying without knowing. That awareness alone is half the fix. You can't release a muscle you don't know is tight.

The companion workbook has a jaw-awareness self-assessment, a 7-day clench-check tracker, and three reflection prompts to help you notice patterns in your own face. Use it. Bring it to your next session — I want to see what you found.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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